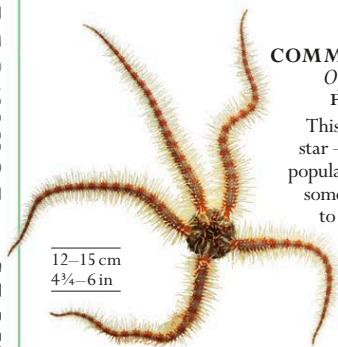


BRITTLE STARS

These animals are named for the fact that their long, thin, sometimes branching, arms easily break off. There is one opening to the gut in the central disc — a downward-facing mouth. Some Ophiuroidea use their arms to trap food particles; others are predatory.

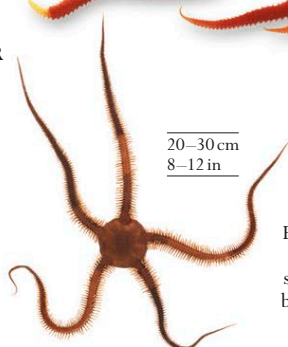


COMMON BRITTLE STAR

Ophiothrix fragilis
F: Ophiotrichidae

This N.E. Atlantic brittle star — often found in dense populations — has spiny arms, some of which it holds up to trap food particles.

12–15 cm
4¾–6 in

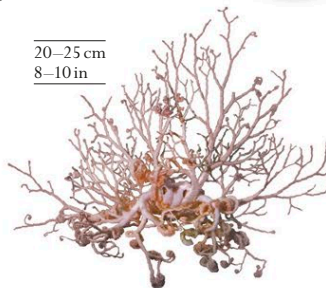


20–30 cm
8–12 in

BLACK BRITTLE STAR

Ophiocomina nigra
F: Ophiocomidae

This large brittle star of European waters can either filter feed on particles or scavenge on detritus. It can be common on rocky coasts with strong currents.



20–25 cm
8–10 in

GORGON'S HEAD BRITTLE STAR

Gorgonocephalus caputmedusae
F: Gorgonocephalidae

This species, named for its coiled, snake-like branching arms, is common around European coasts. Larger animals are found in places of strong currents, where they can collect more food.



20–30 cm
8–12 in

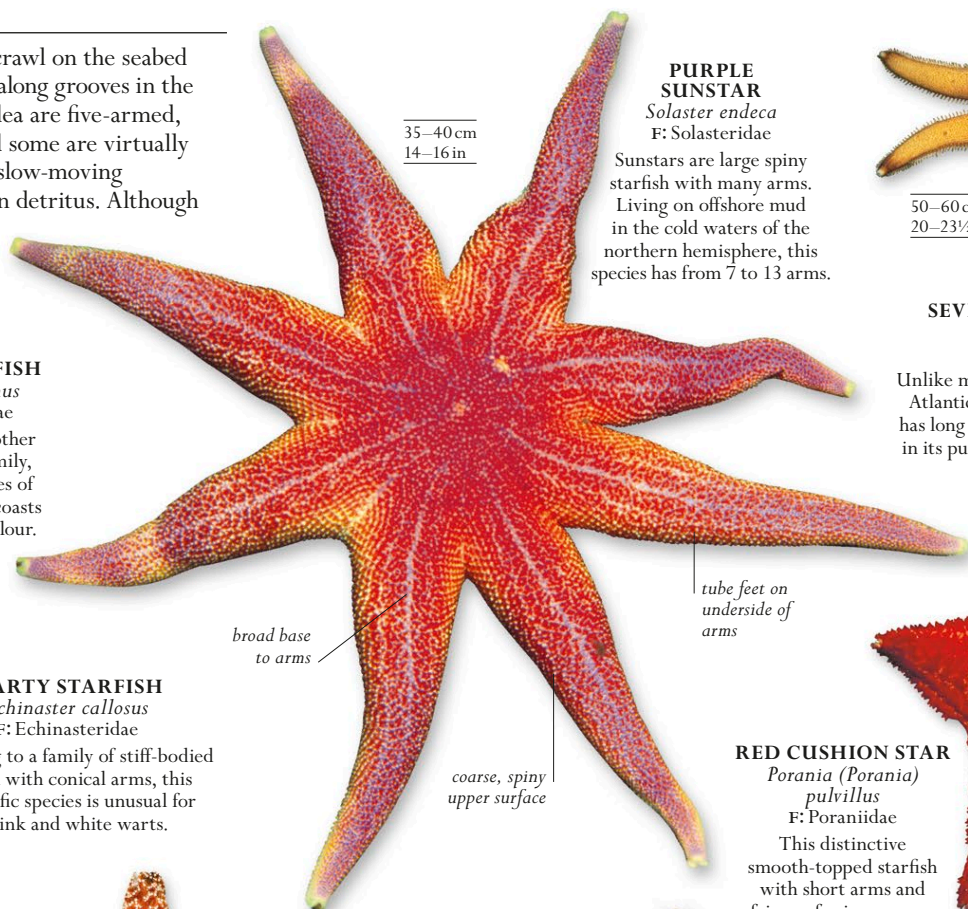
SHORT-SPINED BRITTLE STAR

Ophioderma sp.
F: Ophiodermatidae

A brittle star of W. Atlantic coastal waters, this species lives in submerged grass beds, where it preys on other invertebrates, such as shrimp.

STARFISH

Like most other echinoderms, starfish crawl on the seabed using their rows of tube feet. These run along grooves in the starfish's arms. Most species of Asteroidea are five-armed, but a few have more than five arms, and some are virtually spherical in shape. Many prey on other slow-moving invertebrates; others scavenge or feed on detritus. Although their skin is studded with hard ossicles, starfish are sufficiently flexible to catch prey.

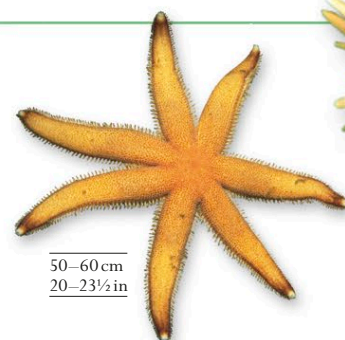


PURPLE SUNSTAR

Solaster endeca
F: Solasteridae

Sunstars are large spiny starfish with many arms. Living on offshore mud in the cold waters of the northern hemisphere, this species has from 7 to 13 arms.

35–40 cm
14–16 in

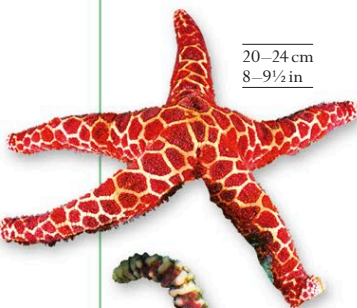


50–60 cm
20–23½ in

SEVEN ARM STARFISH

Luidia ciliaris
F: Luidiidae

Unlike most other starfish, this large Atlantic species has seven arms. It has long tube feet and is fast moving in its pursuit of other echinoderms.

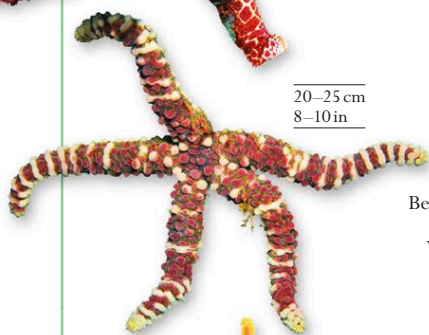


20–24 cm
8–9½ in

MOSAIC STARFISH

Plectaster decanus
F: Echinasteridae

Like a number of other members of its family, this striking species of S.W. Pacific rocky coasts varies greatly in colour.

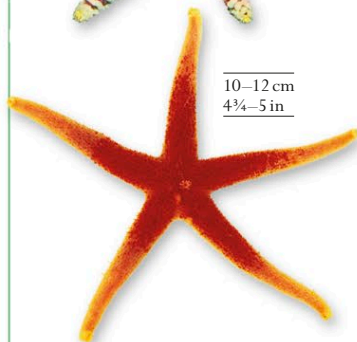


20–25 cm
8–10 in

WARTY STARFISH

Echinaster callosus
F: Echinasteridae

Belonging to a family of stiff-bodied starfish with conical arms, this W. Pacific species is unusual for its pink and white warts.



10–12 cm
4¾–5 in

BLOOD HENRY STARFISH

Henricia oculata
F: Echinasteridae

This relative of the warty starfish lives in tidal pools and kelp forests of the N.E. Atlantic. Its body secretes mucus to trap food particles.



10–25 cm
4–10 in

OCHRE STARFISH

Pisaster ochraceus
F: Asteriidae

This N. American Pacific relative of the common Atlantic starfish — like others of its family — hunts invertebrates. It is an important predator of mussels.



40–50 cm
16–20 in

COMMON STARFISH

Asterias rubens
F: Asteriidae

This common N.E. Atlantic predator of other invertebrates is unusual among echinoderms in tolerating estuarine conditions. It often occurs in huge local populations.



10–12 cm
4–4¾ in

RED CUSHION STAR

Porania (Porania) pulvillus
F: Poraniidae

This distinctive smooth-topped starfish with short arms and fringe of spines occurs on European rocky coasts, often on kelp holdfasts.



80–100 cm
32–39 in

GIANT SUNFLOWER STARFISH

Pycnopodia helianthoides
F: Asteriidae

One of the world's largest starfish, this many-armed species preys on molluscs and other echinoderms. It lives among offshore seaweed on the N.E. Pacific coast.